

weaving A DREAM

✱ Mukti Dutta, 42

Project Panchachuli, started as an NGO to train women as weavers, was registered as a company in 2000

Admission to one of the world's premier institutions beckoned, Harvard's academic life exerting an irresistible pull on the young woman. But Almora's rustic charms were no less. They won. And for the product of a mixed marriage—she has a Punjabi father and a Belgian mother—this quaint town nestled in the hills was a place she would forever call



Can-do Icon
The common man

In 2005-06, India earned
Rs 13,400 cr
through handicraft exports

home. It's also a place where she found her true calling, that of giving the region's hard-working women an occupation, with most men taking up menial jobs in cities and the money not being enough to feed their families.

Mukti Dutta realised that the abundance of raw material for textiles especially wool, easily available, could be the ideal saviour. She also found a way to use plants like the "bichchu ghaas", found in abundance, as a

raw material to weave mats and curtains. Nine years ago, she launched Panchachuli, an organisation for women which teaches them to manufacture textiles from the locally available material. Till now, the organisation has trained 750 women in the art of weaving carpets, shawls and curtains.

Today, more than 800 women from 32 villages of Almora are part of Panchachuli, making it the biggest cooperative organisation in the state. "Panchachuli is no longer an NGO. It has become a brand in India and abroad," says Dutta. The organisation has also begun importing raw materials like pashmina, merino and silk from Tibet and Nepal for the women weavers, whose products are today available in several five-star hotels.

by Subhash Mishra

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My aim is to bring development to the hills by empowering women.

MUKTI DUTTA, Founder, Panchachuli

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